

Civil Transport

Civilian aircraft in the 1940s were a mix of the best prewar designs and “brave new world” concepts influenced by wartime developments. Powered flight control systems supplemented the traditional manual flight controls, and cabin pressurization became commonplace. While the best machines of this decade saw long, reliable service—some were still flying commercially in the 21st century—others were stillborn or made in tiny numbers, because of over-ambitious ideas of what the postwar market wanted—or could afford.



△ Boeing 314A Clipper 1941

Origin USA

Engine 4 x 1,600 hp Wright R-2600-3 Twin Cyclone air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 210 mph (338 km/h)

One of the largest aircraft of its day, the 1939 Clipper was upgraded in performance, range, and comfort in 1941. Providing transatlantic luxury for the wealthy, just 12 were built; all had gone by 1951.



△ Boeing C-97 1947

Origin USA

Engine 4 x 3,500 hp Pratt & Whitney R-4360-B6 Wasp Major air-cooled 28-cylinder radial

Top speed 375 mph (603 km/h)

Derived from the Superfortress, this machine had an enlarged upper fuselage to give it two decks. The pressurized civilian 377 Stratocruiser made transatlantic travel easy, although poor reliability brought just 56 sales.

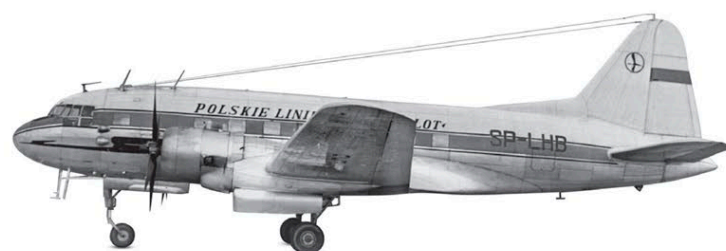
▷ Lockheed Constellation 1943

Origin USA

Engine 4 x 3,250 hp Wright R-3350-DA3 Turbo Compound supercharged 18-cylinder radial

Top speed 377 mph (607 km/h)

Commissioned by TWA in 1939 for transcontinental service, the Constellation entered production as a military transport aircraft during WWII. This first widely used pressurized airliner was exceptionally fast for its time.



△ Ilyushin Il-12 1945

Origin USSR

Engine 2 x 1,850 hp ASH-82FNV air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 253 mph (407 km/h)

Developed to replace license-built DC-3s, the Il-12's tricycle landing gear aided ground handling. Briefly fitted with diesel engines, 663 of this unpressurized transport were built with radial engines.



△ Douglas DC-3 1935

Origin USA

Engine 2 x 1,200 hp Pratt & Whitney R-1830-S1C3G Twin Wasp air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 230 mph (370 km/h)

First flown in 1935 the DC-3 revolutionized air transport in the late 1930s and 1940s, as well as serving vital roles in WWII. Built in the Soviet Union and Japan as well as the US, many are still in use.

